

2.3 Formulas

Now we come to the meat of the matter. Spreadsheets are all about using formulas to correlate or compare data in cells to reach conclusions. It's all quite simply maths, of course, but you need to know how to go about doing this maths.

The first thing to remember about Calc is that you can use regular mathematical operators such as +, -, * and /. These correspond to add, subtract, multiply and divide, of course. There are much more complex ways of using formulas, and we'll get to some of those later.

2.3.1 The Basics

We said it's important to learn to identify cells, and here's why: you cannot work with formulas at all if you do not know which cells you're referring to.

Now, let's say you have two columns of values (A and B), and you want to subtract the values of B from A, and store the results in column C. Let's say the first values start from row 2, then you go to cell C2, and type in your formulas there. The formula is simple: `"=A2-B2"`. If you wanted to add the values, the formula would be `"=A2+B2"`. (All formulas start with the equals sign [=].)

Similarly, if you were multiplying the two values, you would have the value of C2 as `"=A2*B2"`. If you want to divide the values in column A with the values in column B, use `"=A2/B2"`.

The beauty of spreadsheet applications is that they get rid of repetitive tasks. So let's say in the example above, you have hundreds of values in column A and B, and need to fill in column C; if you sit and enter C2 as `"=A2+B2"` and C3 as `"=A3+B3"`, etc., hundreds of times, you will get what you need, but it might have been simpler to do the calculations manually in the first place... Instead, all you have to do is enter the formula once in, say cell C2, then press [Enter]. After the formula is entered, just copy the